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Republican Guerrero sees path to beating Democrat Gonzalez in Long Beach-area Senate runoff

March 28, 2019 | Orange County Register, The: Web Edition Articles (CA)
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OpenURL Link

Facing an uphill political battle along the 710 Freeway, Republican Jack Guerrero sounds confident he can defeat Democrat Lena Gonzalez in a June 4 runoff for an open seat in the California Senate.

Guerrero, a Cudahy city councilman, emerged from a pack of candidates Tuesday to finish second to Gonzalez, a well-funded Long Beach city councilwoman, in the special election to replace Democrat Ricardo Lara representing the 33rd state Senate district.

Now, as they head into a June 4 runoff, Guerrero must try to overcome Gonzalez's apparent advantages, including a voter registration advantage that favors Democrats by more than 4 to 1 in the south Los Angeles County district.

Still, the underdog sees openings to appeal to voters. His platform will emphasize lower taxes, more fiscal discipline in California government and school vouchers as part of broader education reform.

"Seventy percent of the voters so far have not approved of the front-runner," Guerrero said of Gonzalez, who got about 30 percent of the vote Tuesday, well short of the outright majority a candidate needed to win without a runoff. "So you have a lot of Republicans, and independents, and members of the front-runner's own party, who aren't fully aligned with her."

The low voter turnout Tuesday, Guerrero said, "means a vast majority of the constituency is up for grabs."

The Republican said he's challenging Gonzalez to debate him.

Republican candidates in similar races in Democratic-leaning districts often stride in sounding confident, only to collide with mathematical reality. It happened in 2018 to Republicans in three special-election runoffs to replace state legislators felled by sexual harassment scandals. Democrats Vanessa Delgado, Jesse Gabriel and Luz Rivas won those races by percentage-point margins of, respectively, 4.7, 31.4 and 41.6.

But Guerrero, 45, a Stanford- and Harvard-educated CPA and economist who emphasizes his public- and private-sector experience, said he's different from most Republican candidates in L.A.-area races because he is an elected official already, having won two elections for city council in the mostly Democratic city of Cudahy. Guerrero ran in the primary for California treasurer last June and finished third with 19.3 percent.

Gonzalez, 38, who campaigned as an advocate for environmental protection, science and technology education, and economic opportunity for working families, didn't return phone calls Wednesday seeking comment on the election results.

With 100 percent of precincts reporting Wednesday morning, Gonzalez had 8,700 votes (30.6 percent) and Guerrero 4,224 (14.9 percent), well ahead of Bell City Councilman Ali Saleh's 2,577 (9.1 percent). They were followed by nine other candidates, seven of them Democrats, one Republican and one Green Party member. Democrats received a total of 76.7 percent, while the two Republicans combined for 21.8 percent.

Ballots counted so far amount to only 6.8 percent of registered voters.

Though vote totals and turnout will rise as provisional ballots and late mail-in ballots are counted, Guerrero's hold on the second spot in the runoff appears secure. As of Wednesday, 28,434 votes had been tabulated and L.A.

County Registrar-Recorder Dean C. Logan estimated that 5,801 ballots were left to be counted.

Third-place finisher Saleh, a Democrat, conceded defeat on social media and seemed to assume that Gonzalez will win the runoff in 10 weeks.

"To our future Senator Lena Gonzalez, congratulations, I look forward to working with you to ensure all our communities get their fair share," Saleh wrote on Facebook.

The seat became vacant last year when Lara, of Bell Gardens, was elected California insurance commissioner. Technically, the winner of the June runoff will serve until Dec. 7, 2020, but she or he also will be able to campaign as an incumbent, when the next vote for a full four-year term is held a month earlier, on Nov. 3, 2020.

Carlos Ovalle, executive director of the activist group People of Long Beach, said he thought Guerrero was a candidate to be reckoned with after watching him in a campaign debate in February.

"He presents really well. His voice projects. He looks very confident. On top of that, his educational background is amazing (and) he has a lot of experience," said Ovalle, whose group endorsed Saleh in Tuesday's election.

Political analyst Jaime Regalado, professor emeritus of political science at Cal State Los Angeles, said Guerrero must hope that almost all registered Republicans vote in the June 4 election, and must try to emphasize moderate positions to win over independents and Democrats who don't like Gonzalez.

"He's really running up a very steep hill," Regalado said of Guerrero.

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- **Citation (apa Style)**
  Modesti, K. (2019, March 28). Republican Guerrero sees path to beating Democrat Gonzalez in Long Beach-area Senate runoff. *Orange County Register, The: Web Edition Articles (CA)*. Available from NewsBank: Access World News – Historical and Current: https://infoweb.newsbank.com/apps/news/document-view?p=WORLDNEWS&docref=news/17272F37719252A8.